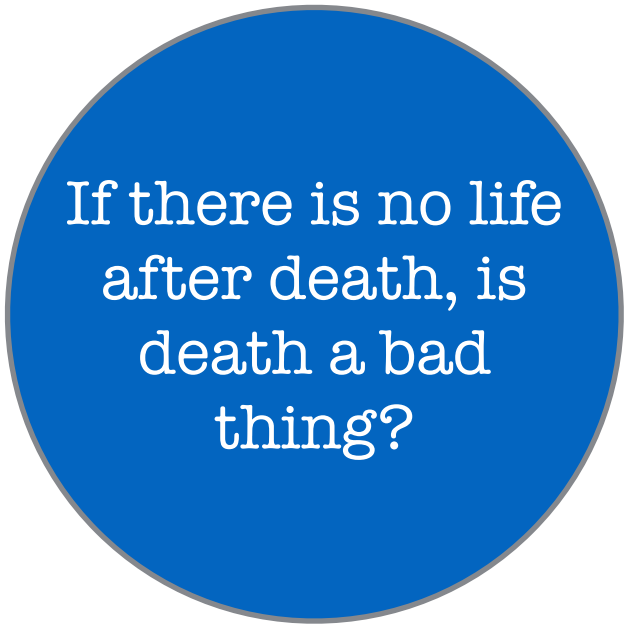
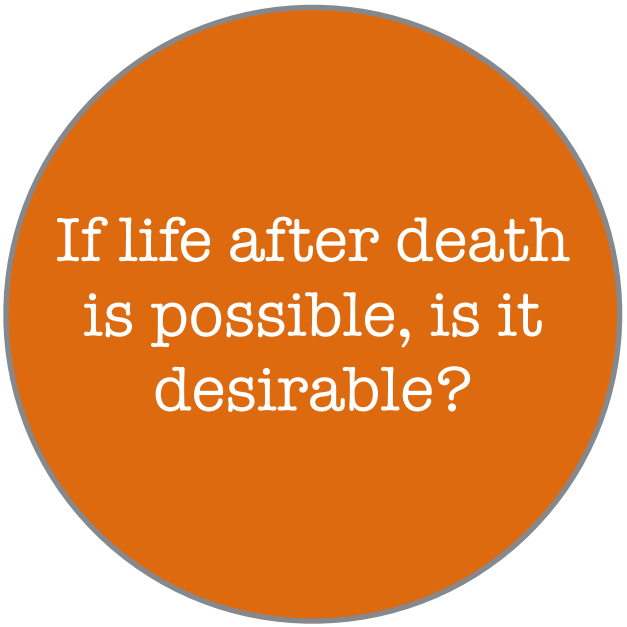




If there is no life
after death, is
death a bad
thing?



Is there life after
death?

A large orange circle with a thin grey border, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "If life after death is possible, is it desirable?" is written in white, serif font, centered horizontally and vertically.

If life after death
is possible, is it
desirable?

When we were discussing the nature of persons, we discussed the question of whether life after death is possible. Life after death seems pretty clear possible on proponent of soul survival or psychological views; matters are trickier if materialism about persons is true, but even here there is room to believe in the possibility of life after death.

But of course even if life after death is possible, that doesn't tell us whether or not there is life after death. Let's turn to that question now.

There are a number of arguments for and against life after death that I'll mention only briefly and then set aside.

The first is what might be called the **argument from religion**. There are as many versions of this argument as there are religions; here is one

1. Christianity is true.

2. If Christianity is true, there is life after death.

C. There is life after death.

The second argument I am going to mention and then set aside is the

argument from near death experiences.

Many people who come very close to death report similar kinds of experiences — a feeling of looking down at one's body, of feeling disembodied, of moving towards a light. One might argue from these experiences as follows:

1. People have near death experiences.
 2. If there were no life after death, people would not have near death experiences..
-

C. There is life after death.

I am going to look at two philosophical arguments on this topic — one for the existence of life after death, and the other against it.

It is worth noting that this is an argument for life after death, but cannot in any obvious way (unlike the argument from religion) be turned into an argument for immortality.

The first argument has its origins in Plato's *Phaedo*. This is a dialogue which takes place between Socrates and his friends, after Socrates has been sentenced to death for corrupting the youth of Athens.

Socrates is unworried, explaining to his friends that death is nothing to be afraid of; death is just the death of the body, and not the death of him.

He gives a few arguments in favor of this view; the most influential is contained in the following passage:

Socrates begins by asking what sorts of things can be 'dispersed.' He considers two categories of things: composite things, which have parts, and incomposite things, which are simple and have no parts.

It seems clear that composite things can be dispersed, whereas simple things cannot.

Being dispersed, after all, is just a matter of having your parts taken out of connection with each other, and simple things have no parts.

"We ought," said Socrates, "to ask ourselves this: what sort of thing is it that would naturally suffer the fate of being dispersed? For what sort of thing should we fear this fate, and for what should we not? When we have answered this, we should next consider to which class the soul belongs; and then we shall know whether to feel confidence or fear about the fate of our souls."

"Quite true."

"Would you not expect a composite object or a natural compound to be liable to break up where it was put together? And ought not anything which is really incomposite be the one thing of all others which is not affected in this way?"

When we're discussing the nature of persons, we discussed the question of

materialism about persons is true, but even here there is room to believe in

the possibility of life after death.

on prevention of soul survival or psychological views; matters are trickier if

whether life after death is possible. Life after death seems pretty clear possible

not there is life after death. Let's turn to that question now.

But of course even if life after death is possible, that doesn't tell us whether or

There are a number of arguments for and against life after death that I'll

mention only briefly and then set aside.

The first is what might be called the argument from religion. There are as

many versions of this argument as there are religions; here is one

The second argument I am going to mention and then set aside is the

argument from near death experiences.

Many people who have very close to death report similar kinds of experiences

towards a light. One might argue from the experience as follows:

— feeling old, looking down at one's body, feeling disempowered, moving

existence of life after death, and then her against it.

I am going to look at two philosophical arguments on this topic — one for the

argument for immortality.

It is worth noting that this is an argument for life after death, but can not in

any other way (unlike the argument from religion) turned into an

sentenced to death for corrupting the youth of Athens.

takes place between Socrates and his friends, after Socrates has been

The first argument has its origin in Plato's *Phaed*. This is a dialogue which

afraid of; death is just the death of the body, and not the death of him.

So crated is unworried, explaining to his friends that death is nothing to be

contained in the following passage:

He gives a few arguments in favor of this view; the most influential is

‘We ought, I think,’ said Socrates, ‘to ask ourselves this: What sort of thing is it that would naturally suffer the fate of being dispersed? For what sort of thing should we fear this fate, and for what should we not? When we have answered this, we should next consider to which class the soul belongs; and then we shall know whether to feel confidence or fear about the fate of our souls.’

‘Quite true.’

‘Would you not expect a composite object or a natural compound to be liable to break up where it was put together? and ought not anything which is really in-composite to be the one thing of all others which is not affected in this way?’

So crates begin by asking what sort of things can be 'dispensed'. He considers

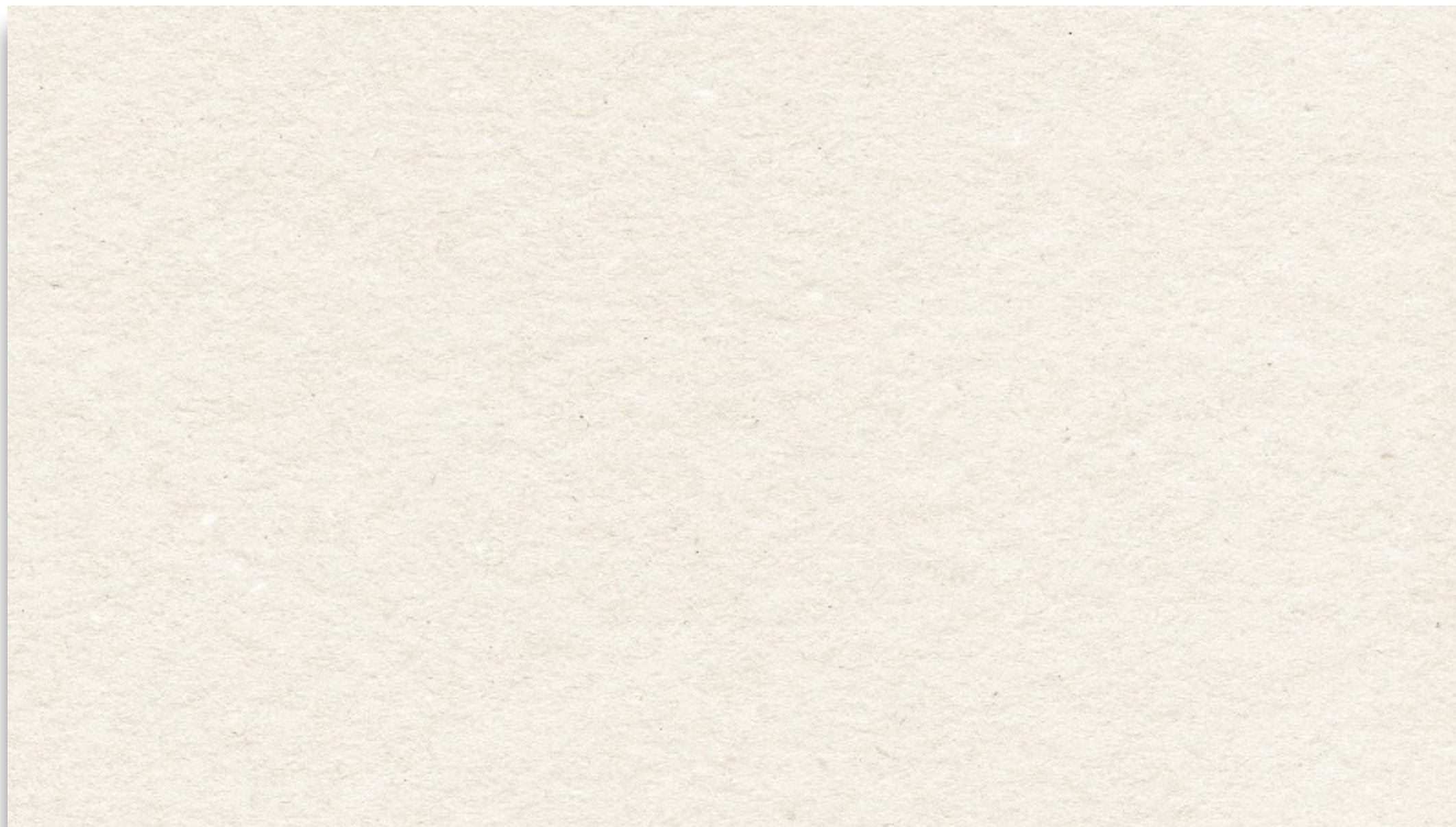
things, which are simple and have no parts.

two categories of things: composite things, which have parts, and incomposite

Being dispersed, after all, is just another part of

competition with each other, and simple things have no part.

It seems clear that composite things can be dispersed, whereas simple things cannot.



'Weight,' said Sears, 'to ask us: what sort

And ought not anything which is ready in conscience to be

disputed? For what sort of thing should we fear this fate;

and for what should we not? What we read this, we

nothing is it that would not vary that being

one thing all others which is not added in this way?"

couldn't be laid out here?

the weather is what the weather is

theater is!

"vieve" "vieve"

'Would you not expect a computer that

should next consider what has the savings; and

Socrates begins by asking what sort of things can be 'dispersed'. He considers

things, which are simple and have no parts.

two categories of things: composite things, which have parts, and incomposite